maharaja and Hope his royal consort. But the actual coronation had to wait for an auspicious time and date to be set by the court astrologers: 9.22 a.m. on 4 April 1965. The coronation attracted even more attention from the outside world than the wedding had done. Andrew Duff wrote in his excellent book about Sikkim, quoting Martha Hamilton, an Englishwoman who was there, 'The newspapers found ever more ways to romanticise Sikkim. "Americans are well aware that Monaco is touched by Grace," an editorial in the *Washington Post* read, "now Sikkim is radiant with Hope." Messages from Queen Elizabeth II and from Dean Rusk, the US Secretary of State, were proudly displayed in official programmes.'[3]

Thondup, however, was cautious, well aware of Sikkim's dependence on India. He said in his speech to the assembled guests, who included Indira Gandhi, then the minister for Information and Broadcasting, 'We recall with profound affection the memory of Jawaharlal Nehru, a true and steadfast friend of Sikkim, and we have confidence that the Government of India will continue to hold out to us the hand of friendship'. He then went on to say that, 'ours is a small country, but we have pride in our institutions, our way of life and cultural heritage', thus emphasizing that Sikkim had its own, distinct national characteristics.[4]

Thondup and Hope had met at the bar at the Windamere Hotel in Darjeeling in 1959 when she was a teenage student. He, then a widower for almost three years, was there to see his two sons at a boarding school in the town. He was nearly twice her age, but they were drawn to each other. They kept in touch after she returned to New York to continue her studies at the Sarah Lawrence College. Two years later, they were engaged and then the wedding took place in 1963 with pictures of the colourful ceremony appearing in glossy magazines, primarily in the US but also in other countries. They were referred to as the 'King and Queen of Sikkim', and it all seemed like a fairy tale come true. The Western media loved it, haunted by the setting of the romance: a small kingdom in the Himalayas with breathtaking scenery, where the people practised a form of tantric Tibetan Buddhism, and the mountains were replete with giant butterflies, pandas, and four hundred species of wild orchid.[5] It was exoticism at its best—or worst.

But what was Sikkim, really? An independent kingdom, as most Western publications preferred to describe it—or merely the last of the